

Teacher Guide

Heidi · Chapter 1: Going Up to the Alm-Uncle · Grade 3

Lesson Overview

Use this guide to introduce the chapter, support close reading, and prepare students for discussion and writing. This guide is designed for a 60-minute instructional period or two 30-minute sessions.

Measurable Objectives

- Students will be able to Identify and describe the main characters (Heidi, Deta, Grandfather [Alm-Uncle], Peter) using evidence from the text (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Define 6 key vocabulary words (avoid, consider, explore, journey, responsible, treasure) using context clues and apply them in sentences (L.3.4)
- Students will be able to Sequence the major events of Heidi's journey up the mountain to Grandfather's hut and explain why each event is important (RL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Make inferences about character feelings and motivations based on their actions and dialogue (RL.3.3)
- Students will be able to Engage effectively in collaborative discussions by building on others' ideas, asking clarifying questions, and providing text evidence to support thinking (SL.3.1)
- Students will be able to Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences (W.3.3)

Standards

Reading Literature

- **RL.3.1** — Ask and answer questions to demonstrate understanding of a text, referring explicitly to the text as the basis for the answers.
- **RL.3.3** — Describe characters in a story (e.g., their traits, motivations, or feelings) and explain how their actions contribute to the sequence of events.
- **RL.3.5** — Refer to parts of stories, dramas, and poems when writing or speaking about a text, using terms such as chapter, scene, and stanza; describe how each successive part builds on earlier sections.

Writing

- **W.3.3** — Write narratives to develop real or imagined experiences or events using effective technique, descriptive details, and clear event sequences.
- **W.3.4** — With guidance and support from adults, produce writing in which the development and organization are appropriate to task and purpose.

Language

- **L.3.4** — Determine or clarify the meaning of unknown and multiple-meaning word and phrases based on grade 3 reading and content, choosing flexibly from a range of strategies.
- **L.3.5** — Demonstrate understanding of figurative language, word relationships, and nuances in word meanings.

Speaking and Listening

- **SL.3.1** — Engage effectively in a range of collaborative discussions (one-on-one, in groups, and teacher-led) with diverse partners on grade 3 topics and texts, building on others' ideas and expressing their own clearly.
- **SL.3.3** — Ask and answer questions about information from a speaker, offering appropriate elaboration and detail.

Materials Needed

- Heidi, by Johanna Spyri (Classic Books for All edition), Chapter 1, for each student.
- Classic Books for All Heidi Student Workbook.
- Pencil and notebook.
- Whiteboard and markers.
- Optional: Drawing paper and colored pencils.

Get Ready to Read

Quick-write prompt

"What do you think it would feel like to meet a family member for the very first time?"

Implementation

- Ask students to think about a time they had to go somewhere new or meet someone they did not know.
- Display the prompt on the board: 'How did you feel about going somewhere new? What did you wonder about?'
- Give students 2–3 quiet writing minutes to write or draw their answer.
- Invite students to share with their neighbor what they wrote or drew.
- Tell students that in this chapter, a little girl named Heidi is taken to live with her grandfather on a big mountain — someone she has never really met before.

Connection tip: Connecting students' own feelings about new places helps them understand Heidi's experience as she meets her grandfather for the first time.

Words to Know Mini-Lesson

Mini-lesson

1. avoid (*page 4*)
2. consider (*page 3*)
3. explore (*page 12*)
4. journey (*page 7*)
5. responsible (*page 5*)
6. treasure (*page 11*)

Activities

Introduce words with context

- Write each word on the board.
- Read the sentence from the book containing the word.
- Think-aloud: "What clues help me understand this word?"
- Example for *explore*: "It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner." (p. 12) — Use the words around it — 'adventure' and 'eager' tell you Heidi wants to go look at everything and find out what is there.

Partner practice

- Assign partners.
- Each pair gets two to three vocabulary words.
- Partners find the word in the text and discuss what it might mean.
- Use sentence: "I think _____ means _____ because the text says _____."

Quick check

- Call on pairs to share definitions.
- Confirm or clarify meanings.
- Post vocabulary words on Word Wall.

Guided Reading with Pause Points

Section 1: pages 1–3

Read from In the cozy little town of Maienfeld, there's a pretty, green path that leads up to the tall mountains. ...

Pause and ask:

1. Who is walking up the mountain path with the little girl?
2. The story says Heidi is wearing heavy boots and many layers of clothes in summer heat. How do you think Heidi feels during the climb?
3. The word 'journey' means a trip from one place to another. What journey is Heidi taking in this part of the story?

Section 2: pages 3–5

Read from Where are you taking the child, Deta? ...

Pause and ask:

1. Why is Deta taking Heidi to live with Alm-Uncle?
2. Barbara says Deta must be out of her mind to take Heidi to Alm-Uncle. What does this tell you about how Barbara feels about the plan?
3. The word 'avoid' means to stay away from someone on purpose. Why do people in the village avoid Alm-Uncle?

Section 3: pages 5–9

Read from Look, she's climbing up the mountainside with the goat herder, Peter, and his goats. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What does Heidi do to feel more comfortable on the climb?
2. Heidi watches Peter and the goats move easily up the mountain. Why do you think she takes off her heavy clothes and shoes?
3. Peter gets a five-penny coin and the story calls it 'a treasure.' Why is the coin like a treasure to Peter?

Section 4: pages 9–12

Read from After almost an hour, they reached Heidi's grandfather's hut. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What does Heidi say when she first sees her grandfather?
2. The story says the old man's face softened into a smile when Heidi called out to him. What does this tell you about how he feels when he sees her?
3. Heidi is described as eager to explore every corner of the hut. The word 'explore' means to look around a new place carefully. What new things does Heidi notice about her grandfather when she meets him?

Section 5: pages 12–13

Read from I've taken care of Heidi for the last four years. ...

Pause and ask:

1. What does Deta tell Grandfather it is now time for him to do?
2. Grandfather asks what he will do if Heidi starts crying and missing her family. Does this make you think he does or does not want to take care of Heidi? What in the story makes you think that?
3. Deta says she had to learn on her own how to take care of Heidi. Do you think it is fair for Deta to leave Heidi with Grandfather? Tell why or why not using one thing from the story.

Read-aloud tip: After finishing each section, ask students to point to the sentence in the text that helped them answer the question.

Think About the Story — Answers + Inferential Thinking

What is the name of the little girl being taken up the mountain?

The little girl's name is Heidi, as Deta calls her when she asks if she is tired. (p. 3).

What clothes does Heidi take off while climbing the mountain?

Heidi takes off her shoes, socks, heavy shawl, and two dresses so she is wearing only a light undershirt. (p. 8).

Where is Deta going for her new job?

Deta is going to a beautiful house in Frankfurt. (p. 3).

What does Deta offer Peter to make him go down and fetch Heidi's clothes?

Deta offers Peter a five-penny coin to go down and get the clothes. (p. 9).

Who does Peter live with in his small hut in the village?

Peter lives with his mother and his blind grandmother. (p. 8).

What is Grandfather doing when the children and Deta climb up to his hut?

Grandfather is sitting on a bench by the side of his hut, holding his pipe and quietly watching the children and Deta climbing up with the goats. (p. 11).

Inferential Thinking

- What do Deta's words and actions tell us about how she feels about leaving Heidi behind?
- Why do you think the author shows us what the villagers say about Grandfather before we actually meet him?

Tiered Discussion Prompts

Literal: What village did Deta grow up in, and what job has she been offered? | What does Peter do every day with the goats?

Inference: Why might Heidi walk right up to Grandfather and greet him boldly when even the adults in the village are afraid of him? | What clues in the chapter suggest that Grandfather is not as scary as the villagers believe?

Analysis: How does Heidi's behavior on the mountain path — taking off her heavy clothes and chatting with Peter — tell us something important about her character? | What does the difference between the village gossip about Grandfather and his actual behavior when Heidi arrives tell us about the danger of rumors?

Evaluation: Do you think Deta makes the right choice by leaving Heidi with Grandfather? Use details from the chapter to support your answer. | What kind of life do you think Heidi will have on the mountain, and what clues in this chapter make you think that?

Analytical Thinking

- The chapter gives us information about Grandfather through gossip and rumors before we see him in person. How does this technique shape the way the reader feels when Grandfather finally appears?
- Heidi is described as smart for her age and someone who never misses anything. How do her actions in this chapter support that description?

Personal Connection

- Have you ever had to go somewhere new and unfamiliar, like Heidi is doing? How did it feel, and what helped you feel better?
- Heidi asks Peter lots of questions about the goats right away. Do you do the same thing — ask lots of questions — when you meet someone new or visit a new place?

Answer Key

Reading Between the Lines — Answers

- **Why might Heidi feel much happier after taking off her heavy clothes and shoes?:** Heidi was wearing many layers in the summer heat and her heavy boots made climbing difficult. After removing them, she felt as nimble as the goats and started chatting cheerfully with Peter, because the weight and heat were no longer slowing her down. (p. 8)
- **What clues show that Barbara thinks leaving Heidi with Grandfather is a bad idea?:** Barbara says 'You must be out of your mind to consider it' and warns that Grandfather will not welcome Deta or listen to her, and later says she is glad it is not her going to live with him. These clues show she believes Grandfather cannot or will not care for a young child. (p. 3)
- **What does Grandfather's face softening into a smile suggest about how he feels when Heidi arrives?:** Even though the villagers describe Grandfather as scary and unapproachable, his face softening into a smile suggests he is pleased, or even moved, by Heidi's cheerful greeting, because it shows he is not as cold and unfriendly as people believe. (p. 11)

Dig Deeper — Answers

- **How does the way Heidi greets Grandfather, walks right up to him, and looks at him carefully reveal what kind of person she is?:** While adults like Barbara are afraid of Grandfather and warn Deta not to take Heidi there, Heidi walks straight up to him, calls out 'Good evening, Grandfather,' holds out her hand, and stares curiously at his beard and eyebrows without any fear. This shows that Heidi is brave, open-hearted, and judges people by what she sees for herself rather than by what others say. (p. 11)
- **What does the story of Alm-Uncle losing his farm, breaking his parents' hearts, and then living alone reveal about how one person's choices can affect an entire family for many years?:** Uncle's bad choices caused him to lose everything, led his parents to die of grief, and left his son Tobias with very little. Even after Tobias built a good life, the people in the village still connected his death to punishment for his father's past. This shows that poor choices can send ripples of sadness and hardship through a family across many generations. (p. 5)
- **Compare how the village people describe Grandfather with the way he actually acts when Heidi arrives — what does this difference show the reader?:** The villagers describe Grandfather as scary, spooky, unapproachable, and someone everyone avoids. But when Heidi arrives, his face softens into a smile and he holds her hand and looks at her carefully. He also shows concern by asking what he will do if she cries for Deta. This contrast shows the reader that gossip and reputation can be very different from who a person truly is, and that Grandfather still has warmth inside him. (p. 4)

Multiple Choice — Answers

- **Why does Deta say she cannot keep looking after Heidi?:** A — Deta clearly states she has been offered a great job in Frankfurt and cannot take Heidi with her. The other options are not supported by the text.
- **What does Peter do after Deta holds a five-penny coin under his nose?:** C — The text says Peter jumped, hurried down the straightest path, and returned in a short time with the clothes. The other options describe things that never happen in the chapter.
- **What can be seen from the spot where Grandfather's hut stands at the top of the rocky ground?:** B — The text states that from the hut you could see the whole valley, and describes three old fir trees and a sheer rock face behind the hut. The other options describe things not mentioned at that location.

Evidence from the Story — Sample Answers

- **Find a quote that shows Heidi is excited and eager when she arrives at her grandfather's hut high in the mountains.:** The text tells us Heidi was thrilled to be there and could not wait to look around. The quote 'It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner' shows exactly how excited she felt. *It was an adventure for her, and she was eager to explore every corner.* (p. 12)
- **Find a quote that shows the villagers are afraid of Grandfather and stay away from him.:** Barbara explains to Deta why people in the village keep their distance from the old man. The quote 'People avoid him because he looks and acts so scary' shows that his frightening appearance and behavior keep people away. *People avoid him because he looks and acts so scary.* (p. 4)
- **Find a quote that shows Grandfather is worried about what he will do if Heidi becomes upset after Deta leaves.:** When Deta tells Grandfather it is his turn to look after Heidi, he pushes back with a worried question. The quote 'What am I supposed to do when she starts missing you and crying? Small children always miss their families, and I won't know what to do' shows he is genuinely concerned. *What am I supposed to do when she starts missing you and crying? Small children always miss their families, and I won't know what to do.* (p. 12)

Character Chart — Answer Key

Character	Description	What This Shows	Quote	Page
Heidi	A five-year-old girl with rosy cheeks who is being taken to live with her grandfather on the mountain.	Heidi is brave, curious, and cheerful.		
		She takes off her heavy clothes without asking permission, asks Peter lots of questions, and greets her scary grandfather without any fear.	Good evening, Grandfather!	11
Deta	Heidi's aunt, a tall and strong young woman who has cared for Heidi for four years and is now taking her to live with Grandfather so she can take a job in Frankfurt.	Deta feels she has done her duty but is now putting her own future first.		
		She is firm and practical, even when Barbara and Grandfather push back against her plan.	He has to do his part for Heidi now.	4
Alm-Uncle (Grandfather)	An old man with a long grey beard and bushy eyebrows who lives alone in a hut high on the mountain. The villagers find him frightening and avoid him.	Despite his frightening reputation, Grandfather shows warmth when Heidi arrives. His smile and his worry about making her cry suggest he has a caring side hidden beneath his rough exterior.	What am I supposed to do when she starts missing you and crying?	12
Barbara	A friendly villager and Deta's friend who joins them on part of the walk up the mountain and asks Deta about Grandfather's past.	Barbara is curious and concerned. She represents the voice of the village — repeating gossip about Grandfather and worrying that Heidi will not be happy with him.	You must be out of your mind to consider it.	3
Peter	An eleven-year-old goat herder who lives with his mother and blind grandmother and spends his days leading goats up and down the mountain.	Peter is practical and a little shy, but he knows the mountain well. He is motivated by the coin Deta offers him, showing he has few luxuries in his simple life.	Peter didn't often get such a treasure.	11

Draw It! — Suggested Details

- Heidi standing on the mountain path next to a pile of her clothes — shawl, two dresses, shoes, and socks — with Peter and the goats nearby
- Grandfather sitting on his wooden bench outside his hut, holding his pipe, with three tall fir trees rising behind the hut and the valley visible far below
- Deta and Barbara walking and talking on the mountain path while Heidi has slipped away and can be seen in the distance climbing with Peter and the goats
- The inside of Peter's small, old hut halfway up the mountain, with its rotting doors and windows rattling in the wind
- Heidi holding out her hand to Grandfather and looking up curiously at his long grey beard and bushy eyebrows as his face softens into a smile

Differentiated Supports

Struggling Readers

Before reading: Show students a simple drawing or picture of a mountain with a path going up. Point to the bottom and say, 'This is where Heidi and Deta start.' Point to the top and say, 'This is where Grandfather lives.' Ask students to predict what the walk might feel like. | Pre-teach six key words using the provided vocabulary list. For each word, read the sentence from the book aloud, then give a simple explanation. Example: 'Avoid means to stay away from someone on purpose.' | Tell students: 'This chapter is about a little girl named Heidi. A woman named Deta is taking her to live with her grandfather on a mountain. Look for what Heidi does and says as you read.'

During reading: Pair each struggling reader with a stronger reader or read the chapter aloud together as a group, one paragraph at a time. Stop after each page and ask one simple question, such as 'What did Heidi just do?' | Provide a simple story map with four boxes labeled: Who, Where, What happened first, What happened next. Students fill in each box with one word or a short phrase as they read. | When students reach the scene where Heidi takes off her clothes (page 8–9), pause and ask: 'Why did Heidi take off her extra clothes?' Tell them the answer is right in the text and help them point to the sentence.

After reading: Ask three literal comprehension questions students can answer by pointing to a sentence in the text: (1) What is the name of the little girl? (2) Where is Deta taking Heidi? (3) What did Heidi take off when she got too hot? | Have students draw two pictures side by side: Heidi at the bottom of the mountain and Heidi at Grandfather's hut. Under each picture, they write or dictate one sentence about what is happening. | Read aloud the last paragraph of the chapter together. Ask students: 'How does Grandfather feel when Heidi arrives?' Help them find the word 'joy' and talk about what that means.

English Language Learners

Before reading: Preview the six vocabulary words using pictures alongside each word. For example, show a picture of a mountain path for 'journey' and a picture of someone turning away for 'avoid.' Say each word, have students repeat it, and connect it to an image. | Introduce key characters by name with a simple labeled drawing: Heidi (the little girl), Deta (the aunt), Barbara (Deta's friend), Peter (the goat herder), and Grandfather (Alm-Uncle). Review who each person is before reading begins. | Explain the setting using simple sentences: 'Heidi lives in a place with big mountains. There are goats and a small house at the top. Today, Heidi is going up the mountain for the first time.'

During reading: Provide a bilingual glossary or picture glossary for difficult words found in the chapter, such as 'meadows,' 'shawl,' 'carpenter,' 'graze,' 'inherit,' and 'hut.' Students keep this on their desk as they read. | Pause at key moments and rephrase important sentences in simpler English. For example: 'Deta said, I cannot take Heidi with me. She must live with Grandfather now.' Ask students to repeat the main idea in their own words. | Use gesture and movement to support meaning. When reading about Heidi climbing the mountain, mime climbing. When reading about her taking off her heavy clothes, mime feeling hot. This helps connect actions to words.

After reading: Ask students to answer simple sentence frames using information from the chapter: 'Deta is taking Heidi to ____.' 'Heidi took off her clothes because she was ____.' 'Grandfather lives ____.' | Have students retell the chapter using three pictures from the text (the mountain path, Heidi removing her clothes, Grandfather on his bench). Students point to each picture and say one sentence about what is happening. | Practice the vocabulary words one more time. Say each word, show the picture, and ask students to use the word in a short sentence. For example: 'Can you use the word explore in a sentence about Heidi?'

Advanced Students

Before reading: Ask students to think about a time they had to go somewhere new without choosing to go. How did that feel? Tell them that Heidi is being taken to live with a grandfather she has never met. Ask: 'What questions would you have if you were Heidi?' | Challenge students to predict what Alm-Uncle will be like based only on what Barbara says about him before they meet him in the text. Have them write two or three describing words and explain their predictions. | Introduce the idea of point of view. Ask: 'Who is telling us the story of Alm-Uncle's past — Deta or the author? Does Deta know everything? Could she be missing some information?' Encourage students to keep this question in mind as they read.

During reading: Ask students to track how different characters feel about Alm-Uncle as they read. Have them use a simple chart with three columns: Character, What they say about Uncle, What that tells us. They fill it in for Deta, Barbara, and Heidi. | Challenge students to notice how Heidi is described through her actions rather than told about directly. Ask: 'What does taking off her extra clothes tell us about the kind of person Heidi is? What does asking Peter lots of questions tell us?' | Ask students to look for clues about why Grandfather lives alone on the mountain. Have them write down two clues from the text and one question they still have after reading.

After reading: Ask students to write a short paragraph from Grandfather's point of view. What might he be thinking when he sees Heidi climbing up the mountain toward him? Encourage them to use details from the chapter, such as the description of his face softening into a smile. | Have students compare Deta's and Barbara's opinions about leaving Heidi with Grandfather. Ask: 'Who do you agree with more, and why? Use at least two details from the chapter to support your answer.' | Challenge students to think about what the author wants readers to think about Deta. Ask: 'Is Deta a kind person, a selfish person, or somewhere in between? Find two sentences from the chapter that support your opinion and be ready to discuss.'

Common Student Questions

1. Why is Heidi wearing so many clothes if it is hot outside? (p. 8)

Deta did not want to carry extra clothes in a bag, so she dressed Heidi in all of her clothes at once — her Sunday clothes on top of her everyday clothes.

2. Why does Heidi take off her clothes on the mountain path? (p. 8)

Heidi was very hot and it was hard to climb in so many heavy layers. She took off her shawl and extra dresses so she could move more easily, just like Peter and the goats.

3. Why is Deta leaving Heidi with her grandfather? (p. 3)

Deta has been offered a good job far away in Frankfurt and she cannot bring Heidi with her. She believes it is the grandfather's turn to take care of his granddaughter.

4. Why does everyone call the old man 'Alm-Uncle' if he is not really their uncle? (p. 5)

The people in the village got into the habit of calling him 'Uncle' long ago. When he moved to a farm on the mountain called the Alm, his nickname became 'Alm-Uncle.'

5. Why does Alm-Uncle live alone on the mountain and not talk to anyone? (p. 7)

After his son Tobias and Tobias's wife Adelheid both died, Uncle became very sad and stopped speaking to people. He went to live by himself high up in the mountains.

6. Why does Peter go back down the mountain to get Heidi's clothes even though he said he was late? (p. 9)

Deta offered Peter a five-penny coin if he would go. Peter did not often get money, so he was very happy to do it.

7. Why is Grandfather unhappy when Deta brings Heidi to him? (p. 12)

Grandfather lives alone and does not know how to care for a small child. He is worried he will not know what to do if Heidi cries and misses her family.

8. Why does Heidi call the old man 'Grandfather' right away even though she has never met him? (p. 11)

He really is her grandfather — he is the father of her father, Tobias. Heidi greets him warmly because she is friendly and curious, even though she has never seen him before.

Creative Response

Common errors

No Specific Details From The Chapter

Some students write responses about Heidi that are very general. They say things like 'Heidi was happy on the mountain' without using any details from the chapter. A strong response uses specific things that happened in the story to show what Heidi felt or did.

Weak example: Heidi walked up the mountain and she was happy when she got there.

How to fix: Ask students to look back at the chapter and find one specific thing Heidi did or said. For example, Heidi took off her heavy shoes, socks, and extra dresses so she could move more freely like the goats. Use that kind of detail in the response.

Breaking Character

Sometimes students write things that Heidi would never say or do based on what we know about her in the chapter. Heidi is curious, cheerful, and bold. She asks lots of questions and jumps right in to meet her grandfather. Responses should match who Heidi really is.

Weak example: Heidi was scared of the goats and wanted to go back home to the village.

How to fix: Remind students that in the chapter, Heidi happily follows Peter and the goats up the mountain and bounces around exploring everything when she arrives. She is not afraid. Students should write Heidi acting curious and excited, not scared or shy.

Retelling The Whole Chapter Instead of Focusing on Heidi's Experience

Some students simply retell what already happened in the chapter instead of creating something new. The creative prompt asks students to imagine something, such as what Heidi might say or do next. Just copying events from the story is not a creative response.

Weak example: Heidi walked up the mountain with Deta and Peter. She took off her clothes because she was hot. Then she met her grandfather.

How to fix: Tell students to use the story as a starting point but then write something new. For example, what might Heidi say to her grandfather the next morning? What question might she ask him? That new idea is the creative part.

No Evidence From the Text

A good creative response shows that the student read the chapter. When students write about Heidi without connecting to anything in the text, it is hard to tell if they understood the story. Even in a creative response, students should use what they learned about Heidi from the chapter.

Weak example: Heidi liked to play with her toys and eat cookies at her house.

How to fix: Guide students to think about what the chapter tells us about Heidi. She lives in the mountains now, she loves the goats, she is brave enough to talk to her grandfather right away, and she likes to explore. Their creative writing should reflect these things from the text.

Modern Language That Doesn't Fit The Story

Sometimes students write Heidi using very modern words or phrases that do not fit the story. Heidi lives in an old mountain village a long time ago. The way she talks in the chapter is simple and polite. Responses should sound like Heidi, not like a child today.

Weak example: Heidi ran up to her grandfather and said, 'Hey, what's up? This place is so cool!'

How to fix: Point students back to how Heidi speaks in the chapter. She says things like 'Good evening, Grandfather!' and answers questions in short, simple, polite sentences. Students should use plain, simple, respectful language when writing Heidi's words.

Exit Ticket

Prompt: Predict what will happen next chapter, and explain why using a detail from the text.

Success Criteria

- Makes a clear prediction about what will happen next
- Uses a detail from the text as evidence
- Explains the thinking using the word because

Example Responses

Strong: I predict that Grandfather will let Heidi stay with him even though he does not want to. I think this because when Heidi said 'Good evening, Grandfather,' his face softened into a smile, which shows he already likes her a little.

Developing: I think Heidi will stay on the mountain. Grandfather lives up there and Deta left her.